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French 48

Professor McLaughlin

Borges's *The Wait* Translation Analysis

Andrew Hurley translated a massive collection of fiction writing from John Luis Borges. Stories written as early as 1935 and as late as 1983 are included in this collection. The entire work amounts to 1200 pages of translated work, meaning this effort must have taken years or even a decade to complete. This type of translation commission heavily influences the translated products, and he expounds on the ways in his journal article *What I Lost When I Translated John Luis Borges*. For example, Hurley became so familiar with Borges' writing that when discovering that an equivalence translation made between English and Spanish was not equivalent in later usage based on the context, Hurley would employ dynamic equivalence, and would modify the mapping to have an equivalent translation in all contexts. In that way, he was capturing the way in which Borges used language more and more accurately. This commission, coupled with experience of Borges' writing from translating some of his essays many years prior, led him to notice many large patterns in Borges' work that would pique the interest of translation theory. Hurley observes that English writers and critics have great wonder and admiration in Borges' themes. From my understanding of English writers and critics, Borges is a 20th century Modernist figure, yet through his inbent prose that brews the tapestry of world literature into a magic that can only be described as postmodern—with *Borges and I* a major theoretical underpinning in English universities. He observes that Spanish writers and critics have great wonder and admiration in Borges' style, his prose, his writing itself. His words were clear and pure and more terse than most spanish writing would like to be. Borges made a radical innovation in the stylistic tradition of spanish. He favored a "plain style" of writing, a style that takes the meat of the story and trims away the fat leaving only what must be on the page. Both languages have their own systems of critique and Borges' work fits into them in different ways, leading to a polysystem theories of translation coming to mind while analyzing Hurley's translation of Borges' *The Wait*.

The Wait is a short story. On top of that, the entire story doesn't cover that much amount of time at all—it can even be argued that no time elapsed in this story at all. It could have all been a dream. The story's main character reached his final, inconspicuous place of hiding where he hopes that the Italian gangster who wants him dead never finds him. Borges captures a certain environment in this story. Everything is mottled and faded and gloomy, and the man can not do anything that stands out at all in hopes of being in hiding forever. The story feels faded and hazy to suggest that this man is living in a state of limbo, not quite on the plane of reality but not dead just yet. When translating the part of the story that explains that the man has given himself the pseudonym Villari, the name of the man who wants him dead, the English text reads:

He said Villari—not as a secret act of defiance, not to mitigate a humiliation that quite honestly he didn't feel, **but rather because that name haunted him, he couldn't come up with another one.** Certainly he was not seduced by the literary error of imagining that adopting the name of his enemy would be the astute thing to do (Collected Fictions - Borges, 601).

The work as a whole evokes the feeling that “Villari” is being haunted by Villari until he kills him at the end, but in the original Borges, an equivalent for “haunted” is not present. Instead, it reads “como un desafío secreto, no para mitigar una humillación que, en verdad, no sentía, **sino porque ese nombre lo trabajaba, porque le fue imposible pensar en otro**” (La Espera, 1). If the Spanish was word-for-word translated into English, he chose the name because he couldn't think of anything else. Using polystem theory, Spanish readers and critics admired the frugality of his words, and English readers and critics “prefer” a translation that Borges' metaphysical themes front and center, which explains the omission of “Villari's” true motives when he originally wrote it and why Hurley may have translated it to be more thematically obvious. Another example is the final scene where Villari finally shoots the man in his bedroom like the dreams he has over and over:

One murky morning in July, the presence of strange people (**not the sound of the door when they opened it**) woke him. Tall in the shadowy dimness of the room, oddly simplified by the dimness (**in the frightening dreams, they had always been brighter**), motionless, patient, and watching, their eyes lowered as though the weight of their weapons made them stoop shouldered, Alejandro Villari and a stranger had at last caught up with him. He gestured at them to wait, and he turned over and faced the wall, as though going back to sleep. Did he do that to awaken the pity of the men that killed him, or because it's easier to endure a terrifying event than

to imagine it, wait for it endlessly— or **(and this is perhaps the most likely possibility)** so that his murderers would become a dream, as they had already been so many times, in that same place, at that same hour? (Collected Fictions - Borges, 607).

The English and Spanish translation have pretty much one-to-one correspondence in this part because of the way Borges writes and the similarity between Spanish and English. The dreamlike and otherworldliness of this story is evoked through the details the parentheticals make explicit. The group came in with no sound, but they have a palpable presence. The early morning gloom mad details faded, mirroring a dream state but also supposedly more mottled than a dream. One can follow both the source text and the target text in the context of their respective polysystem until the final parenthesis. The final parenthesis is not a literary/syntactic device that Borges uses to develop the introspective theme of this short story like the rest of them. Sure enough, when you look at the source text, the parentheses are not even there! Instead "and this is perhaps the most likely possibility" was in an appositive, set off by an em dash like this "—y esto es quizá lo más verosímilpara"! Perhaps this little device was lost by Hurley when translating to English. Perhaps not. This shows the importance in translation theory giving us strong tools like polysystem theory so we can drill deeper into the the fabric of literature—over any language.

Works Cited

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